

Exploring Multimodal Communication in Music Education: A Cross-Cultural Study

Xiaowen (Winn) Ge, University of Glasgow · LKALE SIG / BAAL Conference, 30 August 2024

This presentation draws on PhD research into how music teachers in China perceive and foster creativity, based on three rounds of interviews and classroom observations with three school music specialists and three piano teachers working with primary-school pupils.

Music emerged from this research as a powerful communication tool in its own right. One teacher, for example, taught pupils to associate contrasting musical qualities — light, bouncing sounds with a rabbit; deep, powerful tones with a tiger — as a way of building expressive and interpretive vocabulary. A similar approach applied to more complex musical terminology, such as tempo rubato, which teachers found easier to convey by linking term, sound and technique together rather than through definition alone.

The talk also reflects on a methodological challenge specific to this cross-cultural study: translating educational concepts between Chinese and English. The Chinese term 熏陶, for instance, emphasises a long-term, subtle shaping of character and interest that does not map cleanly onto either "nurture" or "cultivate" in English — each of which carries its own, different pedagogical connotations. This translation challenge is discussed as a finding in its own right, with implications for creative idea generation (Kaufman, 2010) and language learning research.

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Research Focus

Teachers' Perceptions of Creativity & Impact of Policies & Experiences

Key Points

1. Music as Communication Tool: Rabbit or Tiger
2. Terminology – Sound – Technique: Tempo Rubato
3. Translation Challenges: Nurture (熏陶)

Application

Creative Idea Generation (e.g., Kaufman, 2010) & Language Learning